

w2.1- Ensuring Productive Project Teams

Characteristics of Productive Teams

- Common goals
- Shared values
- Supportive and cooperative versus competitive relationships
- Frequent self-review
- Active participation



Here's some things
you'll notice when



Characteristics of Productive Teams

- Focused, pertinent discussions
- Effective communication
- Informal and relaxed atmosphere
- Disagreements are examined and resolved



In addition, when
teams are productive,



Characteristics of Unproductive Teams



- Members are unclear of goals and priorities
- Members are pulling in different directions
- **Duplication of effort**
- Things "fall between the cracks"
- Team productivity is low
- Goals are not being met
- Ineffective follow-up on decisions

There are also
several warning signs





Summary: Ensuring Productive Project Teams (Six Sigma Black Belt Course)

This lesson, part of the Six Sigma Black Belt training on Team Facilitation, discusses the characteristics that distinguish **productive** from **unproductive** project teams and outlines techniques for maintaining high productivity.

1. Characteristics of Productive Teams

Productive teams are characterized by:

Area	Description	Leader's Role / Technique
Goals & Values	* All members work toward common, well-understood goals. * Team values reflect shared individual values.	* Use the Project Charter to keep goals clear and accepted. * Select members who share commitment.
Relationships	* Atmosphere is supportive and cooperative (mutual help) rather than destructive competition.	* Use a strong charter and select members with shared purpose.
Self-Correction	* Teams frequently examine their functioning to stay on course.	* Regularly review progress against goals. * Periodically speak one-on-one with members for feedback.
Participation	* High degree of participation in meetings and activities. * Discussions are pertinent and on-point.	* Work with non-participating members to address issues (time, interest, etc.). * Call on less outgoing members to share thoughts. * Stick to the agenda to keep discussions focused.

Communication	* Effective interpersonal communication: members listen and freely express ideas/feelings.	* Monitoring team development through storming and norming stages.
Atmosphere	* Informal and relaxed, enhancing comfort and creativity.	
Conflict	* Comfortable with carefully examining and resolving disagreements before they escalate into conflicts.	* Disagreement is natural; handling it constructively is key.

2. Warning Signs of Unproductive Teams

Recognizing these signs early is crucial for timely intervention:

- **Unclear Focus:** Team members are unclear of goals/priorities and are "pulling in different directions."
 - *Solution:* Team leaders should briefly **review the charter and objectives** at the start of every meeting.
- **Inefficiency:** Unnecessary duplication of effort or tasks "falling between the cracks."
 - *Solution:* Use an **Action Register** to track all assignments, responsible people, and due dates. Monitor progress between meetings.
- **Low Performance:** Team productivity is low and goals are not being met.
 - *Solution:* If the team stalls in development and doesn't reach the "performing stage," call in **experienced team facilitators or a Master Black Belt** to diagnose the problems.

- **Poor Follow-Up:** Decisions are not thoroughly or properly handled.
 - *Solution:* Keep accurate **minutes** and use the **Action Register** to assign all follow-up tasks to specific members.

The core message is to **take action immediately** upon seeing these warning signs, often seeking help from experienced facilitators or Master Black Belts to keep the team on track.

w2.2- Ensuring Creative Project Teams

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Creativity is the development of novel solutions
to perceived problems.

First, what does it mean for
a team to be creative?



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*We cannot solve our problems
with the same thinking we
used when we created them.*

Albert Einstein

Process improvement only occurs when we
think about problems differently than we



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- It won't work.
- We're not ready for that.
- It isn't practical.
- **It's already been done.**
- That's just plain stupid.
- That's not the way we do it here, etc.



So teams often struggle to break away
from past practices in order to be



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Characteristics of Creative Teams



- Tolerance of risk
- **Low external controls**
- Acceptance of ambiguity
- Tolerance of conflict
- Tolerance of the impractical
- Focus on ends rather than means
- All-channel communication

It's therefore important for team leaders
to do all that they can to monitor and

Tips for Improving Team Creativity

- ✓ Innovate by using tools designed to stimulate creativity, like brainstorming, mind mapping, **TRIZ, storyboards** paired comparisons, Ishikawa diagrams, SWOT analysis, etc.
- ✓ Provide a clear mission objective.
- ✓ Connect the project with big picture company objectives.



Fortunately, there are lots of things
leaders can do to help stimulate



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Tips for Improving Team Creativity



- ✓ Create an atmosphere of safety, trust and respect.
- ✓ Make ideas visible and tangible by drawing diagrams.
- ✓ Use coaching to reinforce a collaborative culture.
- ✓ Make collaboration fun and celebrate completions.
- ✓ Capture best practices and mistakes to learn from.



They can also help by ensuring an atmosphere of safety, trust, and respect,



Summary: Ensuring Creative Project Teams (Six Sigma Facilitation)

This lesson emphasizes that **creativity** is vital for effective problem-solving and continuous improvement in Six Sigma. The goal is to develop **novel solutions** by thinking differently, as the obvious fixes have likely failed.

1. Characteristics of Creative Teams

Creative teams cultivate an environment that supports unconventional thinking:

- **Tolerance of Risk:** Encourage experimentation; mistakes are treated as learning opportunities.
- **Low External Controls:** Minimize rules, regulations, and policies.
- **Acceptance of Ambiguity:** Avoid excessive objectivity or specificity, especially during initial idea generation.
- **Tolerance of Conflict:** Encourage diversity of opinions (constructive conflict) rather than assuming harmony means high performance.
- **Tolerance of the Impractical:** Do not stifle seemingly foolish or impractical ideas, as they can lead to innovative breakthroughs.
- **Focus on the End, Not the Means:** Goals are clear, and members are encouraged to consider alternative routes to achievement.
- **Effective Communication:** Maintain a free flow of communication in all directions to facilitate the cross-fertilization of ideas.

2. Techniques to Stimulate Creativity

Team leaders must actively facilitate innovation through the following actions:

- **Teach Innovation:** Use exercises like finding new uses for everyday objects (e.g., a staple remover).
- **Use Specific Tools:** Employ creativity methodologies like **Brainstorming, Mind Mapping**



, TRIZ, Storyboards, Ishikawa Diagrams (Fishbone), and SWOT Analysis.

- **Maintain Focus:** Regularly refer to the **Team Charter and clear objectives** and connect the project to **bigger picture company objectives** (value to the organization/customers).
- **Ensure a Safe Atmosphere:** Build **safety, trust, and respect**; encourage multiple perspectives and diverse viewpoints.
- **Visualize Ideas:** Make concepts tangible **by drawing diagrams** ("A picture is often worth a thousand words").
- **Coach & Collaborate:** **Ask open-ended questions** ("Why or why not?", "What if?", "How might we?") to reinforce a collaborative culture.
- **Make it Fun:** Celebrate milestones and **maintain a relaxed, enjoyable** atmosphere, as fun teams are both more productive and more creative.
- **Capture Learning:** Document **and share best practices and mistakes** across the organization so future teams can learn from the experience.

Creative Six Sigma teams are essential because they generate new, effective ideas from new ways of thinking, which is the only reliable path to process and performance improvement.

w2.3- Ensuring Effective Team Meetings

Ensuring Effective Team Meetings

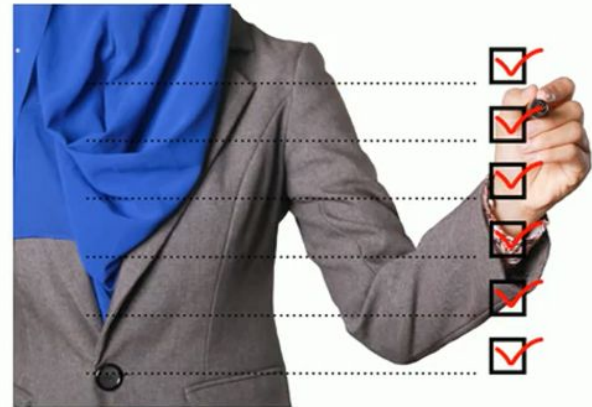
1. Define the purpose of the meeting before scheduling it.
2. Develop an agenda.
3. Distribute the agenda prior to the meeting.
4. Start on time.



Team members will
spend a great deal of



5. Review the agenda and set priorities.
6. Stick to the agenda.
7. During the meeting, **assign responsibilities** and establish target dates for task accomplishment.
8. Before adjourning, summarize the agreements reached.
9. Whenever possible, schedule the next meeting.



The team leader should always

10. Close the meeting at or before the agreed-upon time.
11. Keep a written record of the meeting, the action items assigned, the person(s) responsible for each action item, and the scheduled completion date for each action item.
12. **Edit and distribute the minutes promptly.**
13. Encourage the completion of tasks.
14. Put unfinished business on the agenda for the next meeting.



or before the agreed
upon time to,



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It's also a good idea
to ask team members



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Summary: Ensuring Effective Team Meetings (Six Sigma Black Belt Course)

This lesson provides techniques for making Six Sigma project team meetings more effective and productive, ensuring that the time team members spend away from their other assignments is well-spent.

Key Steps for Effective Meeting Management

Stage	Action / Technique	Purpose
I. Preparation	Define Purpose: Specifically define the meeting's purpose before scheduling.	Ensures the right people are invited and everyone is prepared.
	Develop & Distribute Agenda: Place the most important topics first . Distribute the agenda well in advance.	Keeps the meeting on track and allows participants to prepare.
II. Beginning the Meeting	Start on Time: Always start promptly.	Shows respect for participants' time and reinforces punctuality as a team value.
	Review & Agree on Agenda: Review the agenda with the team to get agreement on topics and order.	Ensures the team's highest priorities are addressed and allows for additions/removals.
III. During the Meeting	Stick to the Agenda: Maintain focus on the planned topics.	Ensures the most important items are covered and discussions remain focused.

IV. Conclusion & Follow-Up

Assign Tasks: Assign responsibilities for tasks to **specific team members** and establish **target completion dates**.

Ensures tasks are owned and completed (using an **Action Register**).

Summarize & Verify: Before adjourning, **summarize all agreements reached** and action assignments.

Confirms everyone leaves with the same understanding and allows the team reporter to verify notes.

Schedule Next Meeting: Schedule the next meeting before everyone leaves, ideally at the same time every week.

Saves time and allows members to block the time slot for the project's duration.

Close on Time: End the meeting at or before the agreed-upon time.

Shows continued respect for time and keeps members focused until the very end.

Keep Written Records: Record meeting notes, action items, assignees, and due dates (**Action Register**).

Ensures accountability and proper follow-up.

Distribute Notes Promptly: Notes should be reviewed by the leader and distributed quickly.

Reminds participants of assignments and allows for timely correction of discrepancies.

V. Continuous Improvement

Monitor Action Items: Team leaders should work with assignees between meetings to encourage completion and provide assistance.

Keeps the project on schedule and moving forward.

Agenda Unfinished Business: Put any unfinished business on the agenda for the next meeting.

Allows members to focus on the current discussion without worrying about their concerns being ignored.

Seek Feedback: Periodically ask team members how they think the meetings are going (e.g., surveys).

Allows the leader to objectively assess meeting effectiveness and identify areas for improvement.